

Philip Moffitt once said, "A house is a home when it shelters the body and comforts the soul." Since 2001, Manav Promoters, a Pune-based property developer, has been making this fantasy home a liveable dream for people in Maharashtra. And the company has chosen open-source technology to bring about internal efficiency, increase productivity and help more people live life king size!

"The Manav Promoters group has been looking at rapid expansion. This needed us to analyse critical areas in which the use of technology would increase the productivity and efficiency of the organisation. A business intelligence tool was the need of the hour, to improve business efficiency, and we chose open-source technology for it. The primary motivation was undoubtedly cost, since there are no licence fees associated with open-source BI solutions. But, along with that, we wanted a complete solution for our reporting needs, which could be easily customised as per our requirements in the construction industry, which are extremely different from what is offered by standard BI vendors," says Rupesh Bantia, director, Manav Promoters.

Exploring the ocean of open source

Manav Promoters' tryst with open-source technology began in November 2009, with Pentaho BI 3.0 and PostgreSQL 8.3 for data capture and analysis, to ensure seamless information flow and quick decision-making. "With a large number of construction projects in and around Pune, we needed information from different projects to be shared quickly with the management at the head office, in order to make optimised decisions on procurement. Thus, we adopted the community edition of Pentaho BI 3.0. In the first phase, we focused on cost analysis. In this, we extracted cost-related data from Tally ERP 9 into a data warehouse in PostgreSQL, using a tool developed by BusinessInsights Consulting. We analysed the data using Pentaho BI," elaborates Bantia.

However, both the open-source solutions had to struggle to win the hearts of Manav Promoters. "We evaluated Microsoft BI, JasperSoft, Palo and Pentaho BI. The parameters we considered were licensing cost, ease of development/configuration/extension, OLAP viewer capabilities, comprehensiveness of the suite—ETL (Extract, transform, and load), reporting, analysis, data mining in one suite, and integration with Office. Pentaho soon emerged a clear winner," says Bantia. Himanshu Sharma, founder of BusinessInsights Consulting, the Business Intelligence (BI) consulting and software development company that implemented the solutions for Manav Promoters, says: "The need of the hour was a complete BI solution. We didn't want Manav Promoters to search for another tool to implement a specific BI application in the future. This is where Pentaho defeated other open-source solutions like JasperSoft, and was comparable to any proprietary solution." With respect to PostgreSQL, its volume-handling capability and cost won the battle. "PostgreSQL provided a huge cost advantage, and was reliable when it came to handle volumes of data of three years," says Sharma.

Manav Promoters is also tapping open source for handling of customer relations. The company is experimenting with SugarCRM, an open-source CRM tool, to contact potential customers and track trends in customer behaviour etc. "We are in the process of implementing SugarCRM and BusinessInsight Consulting is modifying it as per our demands. Currently, SugarCRM is installed and our marketing staff is using it. We hope to finish the implementation in a few weeks," says Bantia.

Winning combination

But has Manav Promoters truly benefited using open-source technology? The combo deal of PostgreSQL, Pentaho and the soon-to-be implemented SugarCRM has emerged a winning combination for Manav Promoters.

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